

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with practical experience supporting complex disputes, case preparation and client-facing legal advice. At BCLP, managed case files, prepared hearing bundles and tracked procedural deadlines across international arbitration and real estate disputes matters. At Citizens Advice East Berkshire, advises vulnerable clients on welfare, housing and family matters: takes factual statements, drafts correspondence, prepares document schedules and manages files from instruction to submission. Experienced in working with vulnerable individuals, translating complex legal rules into clear practical guidance, and maintaining organised confidential records under competing deadlines. Particular interest in court-facing work where procedural rigour and client care sit together.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit **Sept 2024 – Oct 2025**
Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution, procedural issues, legal research and evidence analysis
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy) — 75%
- Dissertation: data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions — 55

Law LLB — 2:1 **Sept 2020 – June 2024**
University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme — Law and International Relations **Sept 2019 – June 2020**
King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of a 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead **July 2026 – Present**
Legal Adviser

- Interviews clients across welfare benefits, employment, housing, family, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements, establishes chronologies and identifies relevant legal and evidential issues
- Assesses eligibility for Universal Credit, Housing Benefit and related support against statutory and regulatory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points
- Manages matters from instruction to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Advises vulnerable clients on procedural requirements and options; translates complex rules into clear, practical guidance

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London **Aug 2023 – Feb 2024**
Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial; amended sections of the memorial and drafted procedural orders and procedural histories
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant submission deadline: coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time delivery
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines throughout
- Liaised with the client on required documents; coordinated translations with an external translator

- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London

Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Supported hearing preparation: reviewed documents, prepared electronic bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Prepared client notes and maintained matter records via iManage
- Assisted with court filings, hearing arrangements, matter opening and closure, deadline tracking and cost comparisons
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines

Q-Legal · London

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

Legal Adviser

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to a formal written advice letter, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations for a data-driven start-up, including children's personal data and adtech; identified compliance risks and recommended practical mitigations
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with the client and supervising solicitor to meet the agreed deadline

Adobe · London

June 2022 – Aug 2022

Legal Intern

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border personal data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries and reconcile commercial objectives with legal risk
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; documentary analysis; concise report and correspondence drafting; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; document review; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Evidence review, hearing bundle preparation, procedural histories, confidential case-file organisation, deadline tracking across multiple concurrent matters